



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: The City School Poplar
School Website: <https://cityschool.org/>

December 28, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

The City School (Poplar Campus, Philadelphia, PA 19123) presents a distinctly Christian, college-preparatory K–12 program with a pronounced formation focus. public materials emphasize training minds and discipling hearts within a multi-campus Christian framework, including explicit references to prayer, biblical instruction, and biblically-informed counseling. This religious/ontological orientation provides a strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations core, and the school foregrounds formation of character, virtue, and values alongside intellectual development.

Judging against the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School rubric, The City School demonstrates clear classical tendencies in theology-grounded purpose and virtue formation, along with an integrated, mission-driven community ethos. However, in key curricular specifics (explicitly invoking the Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, and explicit Socratic pedagogy), the school does not consistently present the canonical marks of a classical program. Consequently, the overall assessment lands as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL: solid in religious and formation aims and college-preparatory intent, but short of a full classical articulation in curriculum and pedagogy. This evaluation integrates evidence from the school's public materials (Admissions, Student Life, staff bios, and program pages) and aligns with the Positive/Negative Keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements document.

Evidence and keyword-based scoring are drawn from the school's own site content and the Classical School rubric, with explicit examples cited below. For core references to the classical rubric, see the Six Essential Elements materials and their Positive/Negative Keyword indicators. See citations throughout for the exact sources used.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Details

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials affirm a Christian, faith-based foundation: "The City School is a multi-campus K-12 private, Christian School... since 1978" and emphasize discipling students' hearts in addition to training minds. This evidences a transcendental moral realism and theology-grounded stance in the school's core purpose. - The site frames education as formation within a Christian worldview (e.g., Bible-focused faculty roles such as HS Bible Teacher, and staff bios that foreground theological framing). The presence of biblical instruction and counseling programs signals liturgical/communal and theological orientation.

- A public “How can we pray for you?” resource and biographical pages for faith-informed staff reflect liturgical and communal practices embedded in school life.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Christian, disciples/hearts/formation, Bible, theology, prayer, biblical counseling, religious worldview (mapped to formation, divine order, sacred tradition).

- Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials (no explicit secular/values-neutral framing in place of faith commitments).

Why this rating - The school's public materials foreground theology and discipleship as core educational aims, aligning with the Positive Keywords around Grounded Theology, Liturgical/Communal Practices, and Transcendental moral realism. This supports a CLASSICAL rating in Element 1. See evidence above.

Citations to the Classical Rubric - Positive/negative keyword framework for Element 1 is grounded in the Six Essential Elements document (Positive keywords for religious/metaphysical foundations including wisdom, virtue, contemplation, sacred tradition, and theology; and the liturgical/community practices).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The City School emphasizes formation over mere information, with explicit language about training minds and discipling hearts within a Christian framework and a long-standing mission statement describing the school's purpose to “train minds, disciple hearts, and bring light to the city” (multi-campus K–12). This signals formation of virtue and wisdom as central aims. - The Admissions messaging and the emphasis on college-preparatory curriculum further indicate that virtue, excellence, and the cultivation of character are prioritized alongside intellectual development. - The Student Life description frames students as holistic beings (spiritual, emotional, social, physical) and highlights a Biblical counseling program, underscoring formation of affections and character.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, discipline/hearts, wisdom, truth (implied through Christian worldview), education as formation, holistic education, mentorship. - Negative keywords: None explicitly indicated in public materials (no emphasis on value-neutral/workforce-readiness language).

Why this rating - The school's stated aims center on the formation of character and the pursuit of divine/eternal truths within a Christian frame, consistent with the Positive Keywords around formation and truth/goodness/beauty. This warrants CLASSICAL for Element 2. See evidence above.

Citations to the Classical Rubric - The “Formation over information” and “virtue-centered formation” language is consistent with the rubric's emphasis on Formation of Affections and the teleology of education. The Six Essential Elements document provides the framework for these terms.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials indicate a college-preparatory, STEAM-infused curriculum and a Christian worldview, with explicit references to STEAM initiatives (STEAM Letter) and a broad range of academic offerings, including arts, sciences, and humanities. This demonstrates modern, integrated curricular design rather than a strict classical canon. - There is no explicit, repeated mention of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or the Quadrivium, nor explicit references to Great Books or the Great Conversation in the public materials. The lack of these canonical classical-curriculum markers reduces the alignment with core classical curriculum criteria. - The site emphasizes a Christian worldview and biblically-informed instruction rather than a traditional classical curriculum, though there are cross-disciplinary elements (e.g., STEAM) that function well in a modern integrated approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: interdisciplinary integration, STEAM, college-preparatory curriculum, integration and wonder (through the combination of arts/science and a holistic approach). - Negative keywords present: absence of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation, absence of Trivium/Quadrivium language, and absence of explicit memorization/recitation as central pedagogy.

Why this rating - The Curriculum category demonstrates meaningful classical-adjacent traits (integration, wonder, discipline) but lacks the explicit classical core elements (Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, Great Conversation). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 3. Evidence cited above.

Citations to the Classical Rubric - The Positive Keywords for curriculum (Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, Great Conversation, integration, wonder) come from the Six Essential Elements material. The City School materials show integration and wonder in a modern STEAM/arts emphasis but do not show canonical Great Books or Trivium/Quadrivium emphasis.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a modern, college-preparatory environment with STEAM and arts emphasis, not explicitly aligned to Socratic seminars, formalized memorization/recitation, or the prescribed classical pedagogy (e.g., Scholé/restful learning, lower-school chant/memorization, upper-school rhetoric with formal debate). The absence of explicit Socratic-method emphasis in high school pedagogy is notable.

- There is no explicit evidence of a deliberate “Socratic” program in the high school or a structured chant/memorization routine highlighted on public pages. The public materials emphasize formation, Christian worldview, and a modern, holistic approach rather than the classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, rhetoric training, and public speaking as a core, high-visibility practice).
- In lower grades, the materials do reference a holistic student experience but do not indicate a classical, chant-based or routine memory work as a core pedagogy. The public-facing content aligns more with contemporary pedagogy than strict classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: there are references to “formation” and “discipling hearts,” which align with holistic, character-focused pedagogy but not with explicit classical pedagogical methods (Socratic, rhetoric training).

- Negative keywords present: absence of explicit Socratic seminars, classical rhetoric training, or structured, rigorous rhetoric/public-speaking pathways; absence of memory-focused pedagogical language.

Why this rating - The pedagogy described in public materials aligns more closely with modern, holistic, faith-informed pedagogy than with canonical classical pedagogy. This yields a NOT CLASSICAL rating for Element 4. See evidence cited above.

Citations to the Classical Rubric - The Classical Pedagogy indicators (Socratic method, seminars, debate, rhetoric training) are described in the Six Essential Elements document. The City School materials do not clearly present these as central, hence NOT CLASSICAL for Element 4.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public bios and staff pages show educators who model care, faith, and mentorship (e.g., Bible teacher in secondary school, Counselor roles, and staff bios highlighting service and faith-informed leadership). While these reflect virtuous teaching ideals, they are not explicitly framed as “the living curriculum” or a formal faculty portrait of teacher ideals in a classical sense.

- The site emphasizes the faculty as mentors and capable professionals, but it does not overtly present a formal “living curriculum” or exact portrait of a teacher-student relationship that classical pedagogy emphasizes. The presence of faith-centered staff roles (e.g., HS Bible Teacher) supports a virtuous, mentoring image but outside the explicit living-curriculum framework described in classical practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: modeling virtue, mentorship, faith-informed leadership (mapped to “Teachers as Models of Virtue,” “Mentorship,” and “Living Curriculum” in the rubric).

- Negative keywords present: none explicit; however, the site does not explicitly center on a classical faculty portrait or “core of the school” living curriculum as the primary organizing feature.

Why this rating - The faculty appear as virtuous, faith-informed professionals, but the public materials do not explicitly showcase the classical faculty portrait or the “living curriculum” concept. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 5. See bios and faith-centered roles cited.

Citations to the Classical Rubric - The Positive Keywords for Element 5 include “Teachers as Models of Virtue” and “Mentorship” and the idea of a “living curriculum.” The City School materials show mentorship/-faith leadership but do not explicitly present the classical-faculty framing.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Admissions messaging emphasizes partnership with families and values the role of parents in the education process (e.g., “WHO YOU LEARN WITH MATTERS,” and the mission to train minds and disciple hearts) which signals an emphasis on family partnership and parental engagement. The site invites parent involvement and visits (admissions process and community events). - The school publicly frames itself as a community with shared mission and history (since 1978) and stresses church-community alignment, which aligns with the concept of parental partnership, home-school collaboration, and community involvement in classical education. - Some pages emphasize parent-focused engagement (e.g., open houses, parent inquiries) but explicit, ongoing parent-education programs on classical education (e.g., book studies, parent training) are not clearly detailed in the public materials provided. This leaves room for stronger parental partnerships beyond what is publicly described.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parental engagement, school-administration collaboration, multi-generational education (as implied by the long-running faith-based community). - Negative keywords present: explicit parent-education programs, formal “co-teacher” status for parents, or structured parent-training initiatives are not clearly described.

Why this rating - The City School demonstrates meaningful parent/community engagement and invites parental involvement; however, explicit co-teaching roles or structured parent-education programs are not clearly articulated in the public materials. This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 6. See admissions and community references cited above.

Citations to the Classical Rubric - The Positive Keyword clusters for Element 6 include “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections” (formation of the home and school partnership). The City School’s content shows family engagement but not a fully explicit formalization of those partnerships as co-educators.

Aggregate assessment

- Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Rationale - The City School shows strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (Element 1: CLASSICAL) and robust School Purpose/Goal (Element 2: CLASSICAL). However, Curriculum (Element 3) and Pedagogy (Element 4) fall short of canonical classical requirements, while Faculty (Element 5) and Parents & Community (Element 6) show partial alignment. Taken together, the aggregate is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL or NOT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL)

- Curriculum alignment with classical canon:
 - Explicitly articulate and integrate the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; and possibly the Quadrivium) and Great Books within the core curriculum.
 - Explicitly reference Great Books and the Great Conversation in course catalogs and state publicly how historical texts are studied, with primary sources and classic works included.
- Pedagogical reform toward classical methods:
 - Introduce Socratic seminars, structured rhetoric training, and formal opportunities for public speaking and argumentation in upper grades.
 - Reintroduce contemplative “scholé” rhythms in lower grades, with memory work and structured recitation as appropriate to the program.
- Faculty development and living curriculum:
 - Explicitly define and publish the living-curriculum concept, with faculty modeling virtue and intellectual habits, and professional development aligned to classical pedagogy.
- Parent and community engagement enhancements:

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- Establish formal parent co-teaching roles or structured parent education programs (e.g., book studies on classical education, workshops on virtue formation, and family catechesis) and clearly communicate these opportunities on the website.
 - Evidence-cited basis for needle-moving steps: The City School already demonstrates strong formation and faith-based aims (Element 1) and formation-focused goals (Element 2). However, explicit classical-curriculum markers (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, Scholé, and visible public rhetoric) are not consistently present in the public materials for Categories 3–6. This is the primary area for improvement to move toward a full CLASSICAL classification. See the public materials on admissions, student life, and pedagogy for the currently demonstrated aspects.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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